



# “AIRTEL BELONGS TO THE PEOPLE WHO WORK THERE”

Sunil Bharti Mittal, Founder and Chairman of Bharti Enterprises, talks about Airtel, lessons from diversification, and more

BY KRISHNA GOPALAN • PHOTOS BY HARDIK CHHABRA

## FOR SUNIL BHARTI

**MITTAL**, 66, a crisis is nothing new and it brings out the best in him. The winner of the Business Icon of the Year award, he has built a telecom business that is among the best in the world. With a subscriber base of just under 400 million, there is a lot to be happy about. In an interaction with *Business Today*, the Founder and Chairman of Bharti Enterprises reveals the reason for his success, among other things. Edited excerpts:



*It has been a long journey for you in telecom. What are the key things you got right?*

One is our absolute focus on the customer... what the customer needs, and I think that has served us well when there was [a] very serious upheaval in the industry. We had a massive following of customers even when we were not anywhere close to the pricing of [the] competition. When the service was being offered free, our customers

still stayed with us and that says a lot [about how] close we are to them. Be it in 2002-03 (when Reliance Communications was launched) or in 2008 when 10-12 licences were given away in each circle or again in 2016, when [Reliance] Jio entered the market.

Then there is our strength in investing in [the] network beyond our capabilities... The [telecom] business... is only about three things... network, network, network. If your network is doing

well, the pressure on customer care goes down with limited churn and higher loyalty. Conversely, if you don't have a good network, you will just not succeed... [so] we invested heavily in [our] network. In 2012, we put [out] our first 4G network and that was four years before Jio. People told us we were too early and that a lot of money was being spent. A lot of people within the company were unhappy with that... History has now shown we made the right decision. Had we not put in that money in 4G, we could have been completely trampled over. The same is the case with 5G, where we had to be out in the market for our customers.

The third most important pillar is people. This is a company that belongs to the people who work here—not to me, nor our shareholders... our customers and employees are really the focal point of this organisation. When they [employees] come to work, they feel they're coming to work for their own company.

When I ask people who have moved on what they miss the most about working for Bharti Airtel, it comes down to one word, and that is empowerment. It is unparalleled anywhere in the world and I am talking about people who come from the US, the UK, Singapore or anywhere [else]. There is no other company where people can take decisions